



BUMPY RIDE: Karunanidhi (L) with son Stalin

TRANSITION TROUBLES

As problems pile up for Chief Minister Karunanidhi, the aging DMK patriarch may well be thinking on the lines of a change in leadership and passing on the baton to the youth

■ **By Sarvanan**

I envy you. Like you, I also want to retire," Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi said in his characteristic candid style at a function organised in Chennai last month to announce new schemes for pensioners. Lest anyone think that the DMK patriarch was about to hand over the baton after 50 years in politics, he was quick to clarify: "But it is not a wish that can be fulfilled right now."

A week later, the former scriptwriter confounded his party cadres and political opponents alike with a column in the DMK mouthpiece *Murasoli*. The column was titled "Make Way for Young", enough to fuel speculation that he was finally ready to pass on power to his son—heir apparent and DMK Deputy General Secretary

M.K. Stalin—at the party's youth conference scheduled in Tirunelveli on December 15 and 16. In another column, the veteran wrote: "Six of my siblings have involved themselves in our movement. They protect the Dravidian goals. They stand by the cadres." He also referred to the tortures inflicted on Stalin during the Emergency and praised the courage of another son M.K. Alagiri. "Thalaivar (leader) wants to lessen his load in the Government and the party. After the youth meet in Tirunelveli, one can expect significant changes," says a senior minister in his Cabinet.

Since then, the rumour mills haven't stopped grinding that the party's over-age and over-the-hill-top leadership will pave the way for new leaders: Minister for Local Bodies Stalin would be made deputy chief

minister and in due course take over from his father while brother Alagiri would be made deputy general secretary of the party.

In a party in which the Karunanidhi family wields absolute control, the DMK patriarch's wish would have been a command but for some hitches. There is a crisis in governance, with law and order being the worst casualties. This has led to a number of frictions within the ruling alliance that also includes parties like the Congress, PMK, and the two Communist parties. They are as critical of the Government as the opposition AIADMK, and with reason too. While state Congress committee chief M. Krishnaswamy had been a victim of a brutal attack last month in Mudhukulathur, last week in two separate incidents on the same day,